Putting Riverdesk online with Railway

This guide is for you, step by step. Riverdesk runs as **four services** in one Railway project, all built from the GitHub repository. The database stays on Supabase: Railway runs only the programs.

Service	What it is	Public address	Recipe
`website`	The public homepage and docs	yes, e.g. `riverdsk.com`	`deploy/website.Dockerfile`
`backoffice`	The staff app	yes, e.g. `app.riverdsk.com`	`deploy/backoffice.Dockerfile`
`api`	The Channel API for nilecrz and other platforms	yes, e.g. `api.riverdsk.com`	`deploy/api.Dockerfile`
`worker`	Background jobs and PDFs	no	`deploy/worker.Dockerfile`

Until the domain is ready, Railway gives each public service a free address like `backoffice-production-1234.up.railway.app`.

> **Never paste a password or key into a chat.** Every secret goes straight into Railway's **Variables** screen. The values are in `.env.hosted` on your Mac: open it in a text editor and copy from there.

Before you start: practical tips

- **Finding `.env.hosted`:** it is in the project folder (`riverdesk`). Finder hides files whose names start with a dot: press **Cmd + Shift + .** to show them, then open the file with TextEdit. Copy each value exactly, with no spaces or quotes at the ends.
- **GitHub access:** when Railway asks to connect GitHub, give it access to the **riverdesk** repository. If you do not own the GitHub account (`desertcanvasart-dotcom`), its owner has to approve.
- **Config file path:** set it on each service before the first deploy finishes. If a service starts building with the wrong recipe, set the path, then press **Redeploy**.
- **Raw editor:** in a service's **Variables** tab, **Raw Editor** lets you paste all the lines at once, one `NAME=value` per line.
- **Region:** choose **Europe West** for all four services.
- **If a build turns red:** send the service name and the last lines of its build log (Deployments → the failed deploy → Build logs). Logs contain no passwords.

1. Create the account and the project (you)

1. Sign up at **railway.com** with your email or GitHub. Choose the **Hobby** plan (about USD 5 a month, including usage credit. Four small services usually cost USD 10–25 a month in total; Railway shows usage live).

2. **New Project** → **Deploy from GitHub repo**. Allow Railway to see the repository `desertcanvasart-dotcom/riverdesk` (the GitHub owner must approve the access).
3. Railway creates one service from the repository. Rename it `website` (service → Settings → Name).
4. Create the other three: **+ New** → **GitHub Repo** → **riverdesk**, three times. Name them `backoffice`, `api` and `worker`.
5. Set the project's region to **Europe West** (each service → Settings → Region), close to the database in Ireland.

2. Point each service to its recipe

For each service, open **Settings** and set **Config-as-code** → **Railway config file** to:

Service	Config file path
`website`	`deploy/railway.website.json`
`backoffice`	`deploy/railway.backoffice.json`
`api`	`deploy/railway.api.json`
`worker`	`deploy/railway.worker.json`

Leave **Root directory** empty (the whole repository is needed).

3. Variables (settings) for each service

Open each service → **Variables** → **Raw editor**, and paste the names below with their values. Values marked **from** `.env.hosted` are copied from that file on your Mac. Never send them to anyone.

All three of `backoffice`, `api`, `worker`

Name	Value
`VS_ENV`	`hosted`
`LOG_LEVEL`	`info`
`DATABASE_HOST`	from `.env.hosted`
`DATABASE_PORT`	from `.env.hosted` (6543)
`DATABASE_NAME`	from `.env.hosted`
`DATABASE_SSL`	from `.env.hosted`
`SUPABASE_PROJECT_REF`	from `.env.hosted`
`PASSPORT_KEY_ID`	from `.env.hosted`
`PASSPORT_KEY`	from `.env.hosted`
`SENTRY_DSN`	later, once Sentry exists (optional)

Only on `backoffice`

Name	Value
`VS_BACKOFFICE_PASSWORD`	from `.env.hosted`
`SUPABASE_URL`	from `.env.hosted`
`SUPABASE_PUBLISHABLE_KEY`	from `.env.hosted`

Only on `api`

Name	Value
`VS_API_PASSWORD`	from `.env.hosted`
`API_TOKEN_SECRET`	from `.env.hosted`

Only on `worker`

Name	Value
`VS_WORKER_PASSWORD`	from `.env.hosted`
`DATABASE_SESSION_PORT`	from `.env.hosted` (5432)
`SMTP_URL`, `MAIL_FROM`	later, once the mail account exists (optional)

Only on `website` (nothing secret)

Name	Value
`NEXT_PUBLIC_APP_URL`	the back office's public address, e.g. `https://app.riverdsk.com`
`NEXT_PUBLIC_API_DOCS_URL`	the API's address followed by `/docs`, e.g. `https://api.riverdsk.com/docs`
`NEXT_PUBLIC_CONTACT_EMAIL`	the demo-request address (optional)

The website bakes these into its pages, so after changing one, **redeploy** the website.

Do not add `DATABASE_URL_ADMIN`, `SEED_STAFF_PASSWORD` or `SEED_TOTP_SECRET` to any service. They are for setup from your Mac only.

4. Public addresses

For `website`, `backoffice` and `api`: **Settings** → **Networking** → **Generate Domain**. Railway gives each one a `….up.railway.app` address. The `worker` gets none.

Then set the website's two `NEXT_PUBLIC_…` variables to the back office and API addresses, and redeploy the website.

5. Tell Supabase where the back office lives

In the Supabase dashboard: **Authentication** → **URL Configuration**:

- **Site URL**: the back office address (`https://….up.railway.app`, later `https://app.riverdsk.com`).
- **Redirect URLs**: add the same address followed by `/**`.

6. Deploy and check

Railway builds and deploys each service when its settings are saved, and again on every push to `main`. The first build takes 5–10 minutes. Then:

- the **website** address shows the homepage;
- **backoffice** `…/api/health` shows `{"status":"ok","database":true}`;
- **api** `…/health` shows `{"status":"ok","database":true}`, and `…/docs` shows the API reference;
- **worker** → Deployments → Logs shows `worker started`.

Tell me when you reach this point and I will run the full checks with you.

7. Your domain: riverdsk.com

Address	Service
`riverdsk.com` (and `www.riverdsk.com`)	`website`
`app.riverdsk.com`	`backoffice`
`api.riverdsk.com`	`api`

Steps

For each public service: **Settings** → **Networking** → **Custom Domain**. Enter for example `riverdsk.com` (website), `app.riverdsk.com` (back office) and `api.riverdsk.com` (API). Railway shows a **CNAME** record for each. Add those records at your domain registrar. Within minutes to a few hours, HTTPS works on your domain. Then update the website variables, the Supabase Site URL, and the Redirect URLs to the new addresses.

Costs and limits to know

- Each service uses memory only while running. The worker runs all the time (holds must expire on time).
- The worker's image is the largest (it includes the PDF engine, Chromium).
- Railway keeps the last deployments: **Deployments** → **Rollback** returns to a previous version in one click.